

marriages in China, only four failed in 1985. Today, 220 of every 10,000 couples will split.

Why is China experiencing this spike? One reason is that the country has recently introduced new (and simpler) divorce policies, making divorce a possibility whereas in the past it might not have been. But divorces aren't the only business on the rise: young people are adopting new ways of dating and mating that are gradually chipping away at centuries of tradition. The Chinese online dating industry, for example, has really taken off; it is expected to break 2 billion renminbi (\$342 million) in total annual revenue by 2014. Goodbye, matchmakers; hello, one-night stands.

If you're like most people I've met in North America, the idea of arranged marriage makes you queasy. "I don't want to be coerced into marrying someone I'm not crazy about. I want to fall madly in love, Uncle Kevin," you whine whenever I bring up the topic. "Of course I'm not proposing forced marriage," I tell you. "That's barbaric. Always was, always will be." Then you say, "Love. Attraction. Romance. That's the way it's supposed to work." Is it? Listen closely: you are a product of your culture. If you lived at any other point in history—and if you lived in a more traditional culture, many of which are alive and well today—you wouldn't be trolling the Internet or going to bars to find a mate. You'd be thanking your lucky stars you had Mom, Grandma or Auntie to find you a partner who was worth your while instead of you, all hopped up on hormones, making stupid decisions that will cost you for the rest of your life. We're talking about the person with whom you're going to share the rest of your life. You can't afford to screw that up.

I'm not going to say that I think arranged marriages are the only way to go. They're not. I'm just saying that at least when an entire family is vetting your potential partner, there's a better chance that a tragic oversight isn't made. Love, as we all know, is blind, but Mom, Grandma and Auntie have six scrutinizing eyes between them, and they have very good reasons not to let a loser or a leech into the family.